秦始皇

中国的第一个皇帝

Qin Shi Huang

The First Emperor of China

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Footnotes mark names, festival terms and words above HSK 4 (HSK 3.0 lists: github.com/ivankra/hsk30, MIT).

1 在中国历史上，秦始皇[1]是一个非常有名的人物[2]。他是中国的第一个皇帝[3]，也是第一个把中国统一起来的人。他做的很多事情，比如统一文字和货币[4]，对后来两千多年的中国产生了很大的影响。可是，他也是一个让人害怕的统治者：他的法律非常严厉[5]，很多老百姓为他修建[6]工程，吃了很多苦。今天，人们对他的看法仍然不一样。

从少年国王[7]到统一天下[8]

2 两千多年以前，中国还不是一个统一的国家。当时有七个大国，它们之间经常打仗[9]，历史上把这段时间叫做“战国[10]时期[11]”。秦国[12]在最西边，一开始并不是最强大的国家。

1 秦始皇 *Qín Shǐhuáng* Qin Shi Huang, the First Emperor (259–210 BC)
2 人物 *rénwù* figure, personage
3 皇帝 *huángdì* emperor
4 货币 *huòbì* currency
5 严厉 *yánlì* harsh, severe
6 修建 *xiūjiàn* to build
7 国王 *guówáng* king
8 天下 *tiānxià* all under heaven, the whole realm
9 打仗 *dǎzhàng* to fight a war
10 战国 *Zhànguó* Warring States
11 时期 *shíqī* period
12 秦国 *Qínguó* the State of Qin

In Chinese history, Qin Shi Huang is a very famous figure. He was China's first emperor, and the first person to unite China. Many of the things he did, such as unifying the script and the currency, shaped China for the next two thousand years and more. But he was also a frightening ruler: his laws were extremely harsh, and many ordinary people suffered greatly building his great projects. Even today, people hold very different views of him. 1

From Boy King to Ruler of All Under Heaven

More than two thousand years ago, China was not yet a single unified country. At the time there were seven large states that were often at war with one another; historians call this period the "Warring States period". The State of Qin lay furthest to the west, and at first it was not the strongest of them. 2

2 后来，秦国[1]进行了改革[2]，实行严格的法律，鼓励[3]农民种地，也奖励[4]在战争中立功[5]的士兵，所以慢慢变得越来越强大。

3 秦始皇[6]的名字叫嬴政[7]，公元前[8] 259 年出生。他十三岁的时候，父亲去世了，他就成了秦国的国王[9]。因为他年纪太小，国家的大事[10]一开始由大臣[11]吕不韦[12]等人管理。二十多岁的时候，嬴政开始自己掌握[13]权力[14]。他很聪明[15]，也很有野心[16]，决定要把其他六个国家都打败。

4 从公元前 230 年开始，秦国的军队[17]一个一个地打败了其他国家。只用了大约十年，到公元前 221 年，秦国就统一了中国。

1 秦国 *Qínguó* the State of Qin
2 改革 *gǎigé* reform
3 鼓励 *gǔlì* to encourage
4 奖励 *jiǎnglì* to reward
5 立功 *lìgōng* to win merit
6 秦始皇 *Qín Shǐhuáng* Qin Shi Huang, the First Emperor (259–210 BC)
7 嬴政 *Yíng Zhèng* Ying Zheng, personal name of Qin Shi Huang
8 公元前 *gōngyuánqián* BC
9 国王 *guówáng* king
10 大事 *dàshì* important affairs
11 大臣 *dàchén* minister, high official
12 吕不韦 *Lǚ Bùwéi* Lü Buwei, chief minister of Qin
13 掌握 *zhǎngwò* to hold, to control
14 权力 *quánlì* power
15 聪明 *cōngming* clever
16 野心 *yěxīn* ambition
17 军队 *jūnduì* army

Later Qin carried out reforms: it enforced strict laws, encouraged peasants to farm and rewarded soldiers who distinguished themselves in war, and so it grew stronger and stronger. 2

Qin Shi Huang's own name was Ying Zheng; he was born in 259 BC. When he was thirteen his father died, and he became king of Qin. Because he was so young, affairs of state were at first run by the minister Lü Buwei and others. In his early twenties, Ying Zheng took power into his own hands. He was clever and ambitious, and he resolved to defeat all six of the other states. 3

From 230 BC onward, Qin's armies defeated the other states one after another. In only about ten years, by 221 BC, Qin had unified China. 4

4 这一年，嬴政[1]只有三十八岁左右。

5 统一以后，嬴政觉得“王”这个称号[2]已经不够了，不能表现他的伟大。古代传说中有“三皇五帝[3]”，他就从里面各取一个字，给自己起了一个新的称号——“皇帝[4]”。因为他是第一个皇帝，所以叫“始皇帝[5]”。他希望自己的后代[6]可以叫“二世”、“三世”，一直传到“万世”，永远统治[7]中国。从那以后，“皇帝”这个称号在中国用了两千多年，一直到1912年才结束。

书同文[8]，车同轨[9]

1 嬴政 *Yíng Zhèng* Ying Zheng, personal name of Qin Shi Huang
2 称号 *chēnghào* title
3 三皇五帝 *sān huáng wǔ dì* the Three Sovereigns and Five Emperors of legend
4 皇帝 *huángdì* emperor
5 始皇帝 *Shǐhuángdì* the First Emperor
6 后代 *hòudài* descendants
7 统治 *tǒngzhì* to rule
8 书同文 *shū tóng wén* one script for all writing
9 车同轨 *chē tóng guǐ* one axle width for all carts

That year Ying Zheng was only about thirty-eight. 4

After unification, Ying Zheng felt that the title "king" was no longer enough 5
to express his greatness. Ancient legends spoke of the "Three Sovereigns and Five Emperors", so he took one character from each and gave himself a new title: huangdi, "emperor". Because he was the first emperor, he was called Shi Huangdi, "the First Emperor". He hoped his descendants would be called "the Second", "the Third" and so on for "ten thousand generations", ruling China forever. From then on the title "emperor" was used in China for more than two thousand years, until 1912.

One Script, One Axle Width

6 统一中国以后，秦始皇[1]发现了一个大问题：以前的七个国家，各有各的习惯。同[2]一个汉字，在不同的国家有不同的写法；人们用的钱也不一样，有的像刀，有的像农具。长度[3]、重量和容量[4]的标准也各不相同。这样，各地的人很难交流，做生意和收税[5]也很不方便。

7 为了解决这些问题，秦始皇和大臣[6]李斯[7]推行[8]了一系列[9]统一的标准。第一，全国统一使用一种叫“小篆[10]”的字体[11]，这就是“书同文[12]”。第二，统一货币[13]，全国都用一种圆形[14]、中间有方孔[15]的铜钱[16]。这种外圆内方的样子，后来在中国用了两千年左右。第三，统一长度、重量和容量的标准，叫做统一“度量衡[17]”。

1 秦始皇 *Qín Shǐhuáng* Qin Shi Huang, the First Emperor (259–210 BC)
2 同 *tóng* same
3 长度 *chángdù* length
4 容量 *róngliàng* capacity, volume
5 税 *shuì* tax
6 大臣 *dàchén* minister, high official
7 李斯 *Lǐ Sī* Li Si, Qin statesman
8 推行 *tuīxíng* to carry out, to introduce
9 一系列 *yīxìliè* a series of
10 小篆 *xiǎozhuàn* small seal script
11 字体 *zìtǐ* style of writing
12 书同文 *shū tóng wén* one script for all writing
13 货币 *huòbì* currency
14 圆形 *yuánxíng* round
15 孔 *kǒng* hole
16 铜钱 *tóngqián* bronze coin
17 度量衡 *dùliànghéng* weights and measures

After unifying China, Qin Shi Huang faced a big problem: each of the former seven states had its own ways of doing things. The same character was written differently in different states, and people used different money: some coins looked like knives, others like farm tools. Standards of length, weight and volume all differed too. This made it hard for people from different regions to communicate, and inconvenient to trade and to collect taxes. 6

To solve these problems, Qin Shi Huang and his minister Li Si introduced a series of common standards. First, the whole country was to use one style of writing called "small seal script"; this is "one script for all writing". Second, the currency was unified: the whole country used a single kind of round bronze coin with a square hole in the middle. This "round outside, square inside" design was then used in China for about two thousand years. Third, the standards of length, weight and volume were unified; this is called unifying "weights and measures". 7

第四，规定所有马车[1]两个轮子之间的距离都一样，这就是“车同轨[2]”。这样，马车在全国的道路上都能顺利行走[3]。

秦始皇[4]还命令[5]修建[6]了很多宽大的道路，把首都咸阳[7]和全国各地连接[8]起来。在南方，人们修了一条运河[9]，叫“灵渠[10]”，把两条河连在一起，方便运送[11]士兵和粮食。灵渠到今天还保存得很好，已经有两千多年的历史了。

在管理国家方面，秦始皇也做了一个很重要的改变。以前，国王[12]常常把土地分给自己的亲戚[13]，让他们自己管理，他们的孩子还可以继承[14]这些土地。秦始皇不这样做，他把全国分成[15]三十六个“郡[16]”，郡下面再分成“县”。

1 马车 *mǎchē* horse cart
2 车同轨 *chē tóng guǐ* one axle width for all carts
3 行走 *xíngzǒu* to travel
4 秦始皇 *Qín Shǐhuáng* Qin Shi Huang, the First Emperor (259–210 BC)
5 命令 *mìnglìng* to order
6 修建 *xiūjiàn* to build
7 咸阳 *Xiányáng* Xianyang, the Qin capital
8 连接 *liánjiē* to link, to join
9 运河 *yùnhé* canal
10 灵渠 *Língqú* the Lingqu Canal (Guangxi)
11 运送 *yùnsòng* to transport
12 国王 *guówáng* king
13 亲戚 *qīnqi* relatives
14 继承 *jìchéng* to inherit
15 分成 *fēnchéng* to divide into
16 郡 *jùn* commandery

Fourth, the distance between the two wheels of every cart was fixed to be the same; this is "one axle width for all carts". That way, carts could travel smoothly on roads throughout the country. 7

Qin Shi Huang also ordered many broad roads to be built, linking the capital Xianyang with every part of the country. In the south a canal called the Lingqu was dug, joining two rivers so that soldiers and grain could be moved more easily. The Lingqu is still well preserved today, more than two thousand years later. 8

In the way the country was governed, too, Qin Shi Huang made a very important change. In the past, kings often gave land to their relatives to govern on their own, and their children could inherit it. Qin Shi Huang did not do this. He divided the country into thirty-six "commanderies", and each commandery into "counties". 9

郡[1]和县的官员[2]都由皇帝[3]直接任命[4]，不能传给自己的孩子。这种制度叫“郡县制[5]”，它让皇帝能更好地控制[6]整个国家，后来的朝代[7]也基本上一直使用。

在北方，草原[8]上的匈奴[9]人常常骑着马来抢[10]东西。秦始皇[11]派大将蒙恬[12]带兵去打匈奴，又让人把以前秦[13]、赵[14]、燕[15]三个国家修的城墙连接[16]起[17]来，变成了一道很长的城墙。这就是人们常说的“秦长城[18]”。不过，今天游客看到的长城，大部分是一千多年以后的明朝[19]修的。

1 郡 *jùn* commandery
2 官员 *guānyuán* official
3 皇帝 *huángdì* emperor
4 任命 *rènmìng* to appoint
5 郡县制 *jùnxiànzhì* system of commanderies and counties
6 控制 *kòngzhì* to control
7 朝代 *cháodài* dynasty
8 草原 *cǎoyuán* grassland, steppe
9 匈奴 *Xiōngnú* the Xiongnu, nomads of the steppe
10 抢 *qiǎng* to raid, to rob
11 秦始皇 *Qín Shǐhuáng* Qin Shi Huang, the First Emperor (259–210 BC)
12 蒙恬 *Méng Tián* Meng Tian, Qin general
13 秦 *Qín* Qin (state)
14 赵 *Zhào* Zhao (state)
15 燕 *Yān* Yan (state)
16 城墙 *chéngqiáng* defensive wall
17 连接 *liánjiē* to link, to join
18 秦长城 *Qín Chángchéng* the Qin Great Wall
19 明朝 *Míngcháo* the Ming dynasty (1368–1644)

The officials of the commanderies and counties were appointed directly by the emperor and could not pass their posts on to their children. This "commandery and county system" let the emperor control the whole country far more effectively, and later dynasties essentially kept it. 9

In the north, Xiongnu horsemen from the steppe often came raiding. Qin Shi Huang sent the general Meng Tian with an army to fight the Xiongnu, and had the walls built earlier by Qin, Zhao and Yan joined together into one very long wall. This is what people call the "Qin Great Wall". However, most of the Great Wall that tourists see today was built by the Ming dynasty, more than a thousand years later. 10

10 修建[1]这些工程需要大量的劳动力[2]，很多农民被迫离开家乡，不少人死在了工地[3]上。

严厉[4]的法律和“焚书坑儒[5]”

11 秦国[6]能够强大起来，跟一种叫“法家[7]”的思想有很大关系。法家认为，国家要靠严格的法律来管理，做得好的人要奖励[8]，犯法[9]的人要严厉地惩罚[10]。秦始皇[11]非常相信这种思想。在秦朝[12]，法律的规定非常细，惩罚也非常重，一个人犯了[13]错，他的家人和邻居[14]也可能一起受到惩罚。再加上[15]沉重的税[16]和劳动[17]，老百姓的生活越来越困难。

1 修建 *xiūjiàn* to build
2 劳动力 *láodònglì* labour force
3 工地 *gōngdì* building site
4 严厉 *yánlì* harsh, severe
5 焚书坑儒 *fénshū kēngrú* burning the books and burying the scholars
6 秦国 *Qínguó* the State of Qin
7 法家 *Fǎjiā* Legalism, the Legalist school
8 奖励 *jiǎnglì* to reward
9 犯法 *fànfǎ* to break the law
10 惩罚 *chéngfá* to punish
11 秦始皇 *Qín Shǐhuáng* Qin Shi Huang, the First Emperor (259–210 BC)
12 秦朝 *Qíncháo* the Qin dynasty (221–207 BC)
13 犯 *fàn* to commit (an offence)
14 邻居 *línjū* neighbour
15 加上 *jiāshàng* to add
16 税 *shuì* tax
17 劳动 *láodòng* labour

Building these projects required enormous amounts of labour; many peasants were forced to leave home, and a great many died on the building sites. 10

Harsh Laws and the "Burning of the Books"

Qin's rise owed a great deal to a school of thought called Legalism. Legalists believed that a state must be governed by strict laws: those who did well should be rewarded, and lawbreakers severely punished. Qin Shi Huang firmly believed in this philosophy. Under the Qin dynasty the laws were very detailed and the punishments very heavy; if one person did wrong, his family and neighbours might be punished along with him. Add heavy taxes and forced labour, and the lives of ordinary people grew harder and harder. 11

12 关于秦始皇[1]，最有名的一件事是“焚书坑儒”[2]。根据汉朝[3]历史学家司马迁[4]的《史记》[5]，公元前[6] 213 年，有些读书人用古代的例子批评皇帝[7]的政策[8]。李斯[9]建议，除了秦国[10]的历史书和关于医药[11]、算命、种树的书以外，民间的其他历史书和诸子百家[12]的书都要烧掉。秦始皇同意了。第二年，因为有人骗[13]了他、还在背后批评他，秦始皇非常生气，据说把四百六十多个读书人活埋[14]了。后来的人把这两件事合在一起，叫做“焚书坑儒”。

13 不过，历史学家对这件事还有不同的看法。有的学者[15]认为，被杀[16]的人主要是骗皇帝的“方士”[17]，不一定都是儒家[18]的读书人。

1 秦始皇 *Qín Shǐhuáng* Qin Shi Huang, the First Emperor (259–210 BC)
2 焚书坑儒 *fénshū kēngrú* burning the books and burying the scholars
3 汉朝 *Hàncháo* the Han dynasty (206 BC–AD 220)
4 司马迁 *Sīmǎ Qiān* Sima Qian, Han historian
5 史记 *Shǐjì* Records of the Grand Historian
6 公元前 *gōngyuánqián* BC
7 皇帝 *huángdì* emperor
8 政策 *zhèngcè* policy
9 李斯 *Lǐ Sī* Li Si, Qin statesman
10 秦国 *Qínguó* the State of Qin
11 医药 *yīyào* medicine
12 诸子百家 *zhūzǐ bǎijiā* the Hundred Schools of Thought
13 骗 *piàn* to deceive
14 活埋 *huómái* to bury alive
15 学者 *xuézhě* scholar
16 杀 *shā* to kill
17 方士 *fāngshì* alchemist, court magician
18 儒家 *Rújiā* Confucian school

The most notorious episode associated with Qin Shi Huang is the "burning of the books and burying of the scholars". According to the Records of the Grand Historian by the Han historian Sima Qian, in 213 BC some scholars used examples from antiquity to criticise the emperor's policies. Li Si proposed that, apart from Qin's own history and books on medicine, divination and planting, all other histories and the writings of the Hundred Schools held by private people should be burned. Qin Shi Huang agreed. The next year, after some men deceived him and criticised him behind his back, Qin Shi Huang flew into a rage and is said to have had more than 460 scholars buried alive. Later generations combined these two events under the name "burning the books and burying the scholars". 12

Historians, however, still disagree about these events. Some scholars argue that those killed were mainly "fangshi", magicians who had deceived the emperor, and not necessarily Confucian scholars. 13

13 也有人认为，被烧的书并没有那么多，因为皇宫[1]里还保存着很多书，真正让大量古书消失的，是后来的战争。但是不管怎么样，这件事让秦始皇[2]在后来两千年里一直被看作[3]一个不尊重[4]文化的暴君[5]。

寻找长生不老药[6]

14 秦始皇得到了天下[7]，可是他有一件最害怕的事情——死亡[8]。他多次到全国各地巡游[9]，在山上立[10]石头，刻上文字，赞美[11]自己的功劳[12]。在旅行的路上，他也一直在寻找能让人长生不老的仙药[13]。

1 皇宫 *huánggōng* imperial palace
2 秦始皇 *Qín Shǐhuáng* Qin Shi Huang, the First Emperor (259–210 BC)
3 看作 *kànzuò* to regard as
4 尊重 *zūnzhòng* to respect
5 暴君 *bàojūn* tyrant
6 长生不老 *chángshēng bùlǎo* to live forever
7 天下 *tiānxià* all under heaven, the whole realm
8 死亡 *sǐwáng* death
9 巡游 *xúnyóu* to tour on inspection
10 立 *lì* to set up
11 赞美 *zànměi* to praise
12 功劳 *gōngláo* achievements
13 仙药 *xiānyào* elixir of the immortals

Others think that fewer books were burned than is usually said, because many were still kept in the imperial palace; what really destroyed large numbers of ancient books was the war that came later. Whatever the truth, the episode meant that for the next two thousand years Qin Shi Huang was regarded as a tyrant with no respect for culture. 13

The Search for the Elixir of Life

Qin Shi Huang had won the whole realm, but there was one thing he feared above all: death. He toured the country many times, setting up stones on mountains carved with inscriptions praising his achievements. On his journeys he was also always searching for an elixir that would let him live forever. 14

15 有一个叫徐福[1]的方士[2]告诉他，东边的大海里有三座仙山[3]，山上住着神仙[4]，有长生不老[5]药。秦始皇[6]非常高兴，就给了他很多船、很多钱，还有几千个男孩和女孩，让他出海去找。可是徐福出海以后，再也没有回来。有一个传说，说他到了日本，在那里住了下来，但是这个说法[7]没有可靠的证据。

16 公元前[8] 210 年，秦始皇在一次巡游[9]的路上生病，不久就去世了，还不到五十岁。有的历史学家猜测[10]，他平时吃的一些“仙药[11]”里可能有水银，反而伤害了他的身体。一个一辈子[12]想要长生不老的人，最后可能正是被这种药害了[13]，这真是历史的讽刺[14]。

1 徐福 *Xú Fú* Xu Fu, court magician
2 方士 *fāngshì* alchemist, court magician
3 仙山 *xiānshān* mountain of the immortals
4 神仙 *shénxiān* immortal being
5 长生不老 *chángshēng bùlǎo* to live forever
6 秦始皇 *Qín Shǐhuáng* Qin Shi Huang, the First Emperor (259–210 BC)
7 说法 *shuōfǎ* version, account
8 公元前 *gōngyuánqián* BC
9 巡游 *xúnyóu* to tour on inspection
10 猜测 *cāicè* to speculate
11 仙药 *xiānyào* elixir of the immortals
12 一辈子 *yībèizi* whole life
13 害 *hài* to harm
14 讽刺 *fěngcì* irony

A magician named Xu Fu told him that out in the eastern sea there were three magical mountains where immortals lived, and where the elixir could be found. Delighted, Qin Shi Huang gave him ships, money and several thousand boys and girls, and sent him off to sea to find it. But once Xu Fu had sailed away, he never came back. One legend says he reached Japan and settled there, but there is no reliable evidence for this. 15

In 210 BC Qin Shi Huang fell ill during one of his tours and died soon afterwards, not yet fifty years old. Some historians suspect that the "elixirs" he regularly took may have contained mercury, which damaged his health instead. That a man who spent his life seeking immortality may have been harmed by those very medicines is truly one of history's ironies. 16

秦始皇陵[1]和兵马俑[2]

17 秦始皇[3]刚当上秦国[4]国王[5]的时候，就开始为自己修建[6]陵墓[7]了，前后修了三十多年。他的陵墓在今天的西安[8]附近，外面看起来像一座小山。据[9]《史记[10]》记载，陵墓里面有宫殿[11]，还用水银做成了江河和大海。现代科学家检测过陵墓上面的土，发现里面的水银含量确实特别高。因为担心保护不好里面的文物[12]，直到今天，主[13]墓[14]还没有被打开。

18 1974年春天，西安附近的几个农民在地里打井[15]，挖[16]出了一些陶片[17]。他们没有想到，这是一个震惊[18]世界的发现。

1 秦始皇陵 *Qín Shǐhuáng Líng* the Mausoleum of Qin Shi Huang
2 兵马俑 *bīngmǎyǒng* terracotta warriors
3 秦始皇 *Qín Shǐhuáng* Qin Shi Huang, the First Emperor (259–210 BC)
4 秦国 *Qínguó* the State of Qin
5 国王 *guówáng* king
6 修建 *xiūjiàn* to build
7 陵墓 *língmù* tomb, mausoleum
8 西安 *Xī'ān* Xi'an
9 据 *jù* according to
10 史记 *Shǐjì* Records of the Grand Historian
11 宫殿 *gōngdiàn* palace
12 文物 *wénwù* cultural relics
13 主 *zhǔ* main
14 墓 *mù* tomb
15 井 *jǐng* well
16 挖 *wā* to dig
17 陶片 *táopiàn* pottery shards
18 震惊 *zhènjīng* to astonish

The Mausoleum and the Terracotta Army

As soon as Qin Shi Huang became king of Qin, work began on his tomb, 17
and it went on for more than thirty years. The tomb lies near today's Xi'an, and from the outside it looks like a small hill. According to the Records of the Grand Historian, inside the tomb there are palaces, and rivers and seas made of mercury. Modern scientists who tested the soil over the tomb found that its mercury content is indeed unusually high. Because of worries that the relics inside could not be properly protected, the main tomb has still not been opened.

In the spring of 1974, some farmers near Xi'an were digging a well in their 18
field when they turned up pieces of pottery. They had no idea that this would be a discovery that astonished the world.

18 考古学家在那里发现了几个巨大的坑[1]，里面有成千上万[2]个和真人一样大的陶俑[3]，有士兵，也有战马和战车。这就是有名的“兵马俑[4]”。

19 据[5]估计[6]，兵马俑一共有八千个左右，现在挖[7]出来的只是其中一部分。最让人吃惊的是，每个士兵的脸都不一样，表情、发型[8]和衣服也各有不同。刚做好的时候，兵马俑身上都有鲜艳[9]的颜色，可是挖出来以后，接触[10]到空气，颜色很快就消失了。所以现在考古学家挖得非常小心、非常慢。1987年，秦始皇陵[11]被列入《世界遗产名录》，每年都有几百万游客来这里参观。

1 坑 *kēng* pit
2 成千上万 *chéngqiān shàngwàn* thousands upon thousands
3 陶俑 *táoyǒng* pottery figure
4 兵马俑 *bīngmǎyǒng* terracotta warriors
5 据 *jù* according to
6 估计 *gūjì* to estimate
7 挖 *wā* to dig
8 发型 *fàxíng* hairstyle
9 鲜艳 *xiānyàn* bright, vivid
10 接触 *jiēchù* to come into contact with
11 秦始皇陵 *Qín Shǐhuáng Líng* the Mausoleum of Qin Shi Huang

Archaeologists found several huge pits there, containing thousands of life-size 18
pottery figures: soldiers, as well as war horses and chariots. These are the famous terracotta warriors.

It is estimated that there are about eight thousand figures in all; only part 19
of them have been excavated so far. Most astonishing of all, every soldier's face is different, and their expressions, hairstyles and clothing vary too. When they were first made, the figures were painted in bright colours, but once dug up and exposed to the air the colours quickly faded away. That is why archaeologists now dig very carefully and very slowly. In 1987 the mausoleum was added to the World Heritage List, and millions of tourists visit it every year.

秦朝[1]的灭亡[2]和后人[3]的评价

20 秦始皇[4]希望他的帝国[5]能传一万代，可是事实正好相反。他死后，大臣[6]赵高[7]和李斯[8]改了他的遗诏[9]，让他的小儿子胡亥[10]当上了皇帝[11]，也就是“秦二世[12]”。秦二世比他父亲更残酷[13]，老百姓再也受不了了。公元前[14]209年，农民陈胜[15]、吴广[16]带头[17]起义，很快全国各地都有人起来反抗[18]秦朝。公元前207年，秦朝灭亡了，从统一到灭亡，一共只有十五年左右。

21 秦朝虽然很快就灭亡了，但是它建立的很多制度并没有消失。

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1 秦朝 *Qíncháo* the Qin dynasty (221–207 BC)
2 灭亡 *mièwáng* downfall
3 后人 *hòurén* later generations
4 秦始皇 *Qín Shǐhuáng* Qin Shi Huang, the First Emperor (259–210 BC)
5 帝国 *dìguó* empire
6 大臣 *dàchén* minister, high official
7 赵高 *Zhào Gāo* Zhao Gao, court eunuch and official
8 李斯 *Lǐ Sī* Li Si, Qin statesman
9 遗诏 *yízhào* the late emperor's final edict
10 胡亥 *Hú Hài* Huhai, younger son of Qin Shi Huang
11 皇帝 *huángdì* emperor
12 秦二世 *Qín Èrshì* the Second Emperor of Qin
13 残酷 *cánkù* cruel
14 公元前 *gōngyuánqián* BC
15 陈胜 *Chén Shèng* Chen Sheng, rebel leader
16 吴广 *Wú Guǎng* Wu Guang, rebel leader
17 带头 *dàitóu* to take the lead
18 反抗 *fǎnkàng* to resist

The Fall of the Qin and the Verdict of History

Qin Shi Huang had hoped his empire would last ten thousand generations, but exactly the opposite happened. After his death, the official Zhao Gao and Li Si altered his final edict and put his younger son Huhai on the throne as the "Second Emperor of Qin". The Second Emperor was even crueller than his father, and the people could bear it no longer. In 209 BC the peasants Chen Sheng and Wu Guang led an uprising, and soon there were revolts against the Qin all over the country. In 207 BC the Qin dynasty fell; from unification to collapse it had lasted only about fifteen years. 20

Although the Qin fell so quickly, many of the institutions it created did not disappear. 21

21 后来的汉朝[1]继续使用统一的文字和货币[2]，也在很多地方保留了郡县制[3]，只是把法律改得宽松[4]了一些。所以有人说，秦朝[5]虽然很短，却为后来两千年的中国打下了基础。

22 那么，秦始皇[6]到底是一个伟大的皇帝[7]，还是一个暴君[8]呢？两千多年来，人们一直在讨论这个问题。很长时间里，大多数读书人批评他，因为他的统治太[9]残酷[10]，还烧了书。也有很多人认为，他结束了几百年的战争，建立了统一的国家，他的功劳[11]是很大的。今天，大部分历史学家觉得这两种看法都有道理：他的改革[12]影响深远[13]，但是这些改革的代价[14]，是无数普通人的痛苦和生命。

1 汉朝 *Hàncháo* the Han dynasty (206 BC–AD 220)
2 货币 *huòbì* currency
3 郡县制 *jùnxiànzhì* system of commanderies and counties
4 宽松 *kuānsōng* lenient, relaxed
5 秦朝 *Qíncháo* the Qin dynasty (221–207 BC)
6 秦始皇 *Qín Shǐhuáng* Qin Shi Huang, the First Emperor (259–210 BC)
7 皇帝 *huángdì* emperor
8 暴君 *bàojūn* tyrant
9 统治 *tǒngzhì* to rule
10 残酷 *cánkù* cruel
11 功劳 *gōngláo* achievements
12 改革 *gǎigé* reform
13 深远 *shēnyuǎn* far-reaching
14 代价 *dàijià* price, cost

The Han dynasty that followed kept the unified script and currency and re- 21
tained the commandery-and-county system in much of the country, only making the laws somewhat milder. So it is said that, short as it was, the Qin laid the foundations for the next two thousand years of China.

So was Qin Shi Huang a great emperor or a tyrant? People have been de- 22
bating this question for more than two thousand years. For a long time most scholars condemned him, because his rule was so cruel and because he burned books. Many others argue that he ended centuries of war and built a unified state, and that his achievements were great. Today most historians feel that both views have merit: his reforms had far-reaching effects, but their price was the suffering and the lives of countless ordinary people.

结语

23 如果你去西安[†]，站在兵马俑[‡]面前，看着这些两千多年前的士兵，你也许会想起这个复杂的皇帝[§]。他让中国第一次成为一个统一的国家，也让很多人付出了沉重的代价[¶]。他的故事告诉我们，历史上的人物[*]往往不是简单的好人或者坏人。

† 西安 *Xī'ān* Xi'an
‡ 兵马俑 *bīngmǎyǒng* terracotta warriors
§ 皇帝 *huángdì* emperor
¶ 代价 *dàijià* price, cost
* 人物 *rénwù* figure, personage

In Closing

If you go to Xi'an and stand before the terracotta warriors, looking at these soldiers from more than two thousand years ago, you may find yourself thinking about this complicated emperor. He made China a unified country for the first time, and he made a great many people pay a heavy price for it. His story reminds us that historical figures are rarely simply good or simply bad.

23